Get taken seriously with zero clients

The proof kit you can build in a weekend. You don't need a portfolio to land your first client. You need proof that you can do the work, shown in a way an owner can check in 30 seconds.

Why proof matters more than pitch

- In a GoDaddy survey of small business owners, 64% said they'd feel suspicious of a web professional with no reviews, and many said they'd rather hire someone they know than pick from a portfolio.
- Owners judge you the way their customers judge them: BrightLocal's 2026 survey found 47% of consumers won't use a local business with fewer than 20 reviews.

So lead with something they can SEE about their own business, and borrow trust from people they know.

The 6-piece proof kit

1. A preview site for each top lead (the strongest proof there is)

Build their site before you pitch: their name, services, real reviews and photos from their Google listing. RankSite builds one from a Google Maps link in about 2 minutes (first site free), or use any builder you like. Keep it unpublished and clearly marked "preview" until they say yes.

2. Two or three demo sites in your niche

A demo for a made-up business in your trade ("Northside Pressure Washing, demo site") shows what you build for that kind of owner. Label every demo as a demo. Never use a real business's name, logo or reviews without permission, and never put fake testimonials or fake reviews on a demo.

3. A "what customers see today" sheet for each lead

One page: a screenshot of what shows up when you Google them (no site, a broken page, a Facebook page, a competitor on top) next to a screenshot of the preview. It turns "you need a website" into something they can see.

4. Your own simple website

One page is enough: who you help, what you do (your one-line offer), your three packages, a demo or two, and how to reach you. Add case studies as soon as you have them.

5. A Google Business Profile, only if you qualify

Google only allows a profile for businesses that meet customers in person (at your place or theirs). If you visit clients, you can set one up as a service-area business with your home address hidden. If you work 100% online, you don't qualify: skip it and let your site and testimonials do the work. Reviews only from real clients.

6. Founding clients

Your first 2 or 3 clients at a lower price, in writing, in exchange for a testimonial they approve, permission to show the before/after as a case study, and one introduction. Ask for a Google review the normal way, never as part of the deal (Google doesn't allow reviews in exchange for anything).

The 30-second credibility line

> "I'm new on my own, so instead of a long portfolio I build the site first. This one's yours: your reviews, your services, your phone number. If you like it, I put it live this week. If not, no hard feelings."

Never do this

- fake reviews, testimonials or "trusted by" logos
- a portfolio of real businesses you didn't work for
- claiming years of experience, awards or certifications you don't have
- calling a price "limited" when it isn't

Checklist

- □ 1 preview site for your best lead
- □ 2 demo sites in your niche, labelled as demos
- □ a "what customers see today" sheet template
- □ your one-page site with your offer and packages
- □ Google Business Profile (only if you meet clients in person)

- □ your founding-client deal, written down

Free skills that find the businesses and build the previews: github.com/WordRocket/local-client-finder · RankSite: app.ranksite.ai (our own tool; your first site is free). Sources: GoDaddy "What clients want" survey; BrightLocal Local Consumer Review Survey 2026 (1,002 US adults); Google Business Profile eligibility guidelines. Results vary.